



Planning a Website

To succeed in today's marketplace, an online presence is essential. A professional-looking website will help you grab and retain people's attention. Careful planning will save you time, effort, and money—and deliver a better result.

Thinking about content

A website's look and feel are important, but engaging content is what really attracts visitors to your site. Before writing any text, taking photos, or drafting designs, outline what the content of your website will be when it launches, how it will be structured (see below), and how you will amend and add to the content as your business develops.

Consider your site's purpose: a site that provides content (information), for example, has very different requirements from one through which people will be making purchases (see box, right). Think about your

target audience and investigate what kind of content is working well on similar sites, from instructional videos to popular photo stories.

Choosing a domain name

Deciding on the right domain name—your website's address on the internet—is as important as selecting the right business name (see pp.58–59). The domain name and business's name do not need to be the same, although this can be helpful. Your domain name should describe the business and contain key words for search engines. For example, a bike repair shop might

Mapping your site's structure

Sketching out a possible structure for your website is a useful way to decide how best to order the content, even if you are simply using an existing website template (see pp.116–117). A simple, pyramid-like hierarchy—from home page at the top to main categories, then subcategories—makes it easy for users to navigate the site. It also helps search engines find and index the content swiftly. This, in turn, improves the chance of your site appearing higher up in the results of internet searches (known as search engine optimization).

